Phishing & Message Scams

Knowledge document for the AI Digital Safety & Scam Prevention Assistant

Core safety rule: Do not click suspicious links, open unexpected attachments, share OTPs/PINs/passwords, or enter banking details after following an unverified message.

1. What is phishing?

Phishing is a social-engineering attack in which someone pretends to be a trusted person or organization to trick a user into revealing information, clicking a harmful link, opening an unsafe attachment, installing malicious software, or sending money. It can arrive through email, SMS, messaging apps, social media, phone calls, or fake websites.

2. Common warning signs

Warning sign	What to look for
Urgency or threats	Messages saying an account will be blocked, a parcel returned, or a service stopped unless you act immediately.
Unexpected links	A link asks you to sign in, verify KYC, claim a prize, pay a fee, or update account details.
Look-alike sender	The sender name looks familiar, but the full email address, phone number, or domain does not match the genuine organization.
Requests for secrets	Someone asks for an OTP, PIN, password, CVV, recovery code, or remote access to your device.
Unexpected attachments	An unknown sender asks you to open an attachment or install an app/APK.
Too-good-to-be-true offers	Unexpected prizes, refunds, job offers, cashback, or investment returns that require payment or sensitive details.

3. How to check a suspicious message safely

1. Do not tap the link or open the attachment.

2. Check the full sender address or phone number. A familiar display name alone does not prove the sender is genuine.

3. Inspect the domain carefully, but remember that a professional-looking website can still be fraudulent.

4. If the message claims to be from a bank, employer, delivery company, or government service, open the official app or type the known official website address yourself. Do not use the message link.

5. Contact the organization using contact details from its official website or app, not the message.

6. If appropriate, report the message through the email or messaging service's spam/phishing reporting option.

4. Example messages and safer responses

Fake account warning

Example: “Your bank account will be blocked in 30 minutes. Click here to complete KYC.”

Safer response: Do not click. Open the bank's official app or contact the bank using verified contact details.

Fake parcel message

Example: “Your parcel is on hold. Pay a small fee using this link.”

Safer response: Check the shipment through the delivery company's official website or app.

Fake job or prize message

Example: “You are selected for a job/prize. Pay a registration or release fee now.”

Safer response: Verify the employer or offer independently. Treat demands for upfront payment as a serious warning sign.

OTP request

Example: “I am support staff. Tell me the OTP so I can secure your account.”

Safer response: Never share an OTP, PIN, password, CVV, or recovery code with another person.

5. If you clicked a link or entered information

• If you only opened a page, close it and do not enter information or download anything. A click alone does not prove your device is compromised.

• If you entered a password, use the genuine service's official app/site to change it immediately. Change it anywhere else you reused it, and enable multi-factor authentication where available.

• If you installed an app or file, stop using it, disconnect the affected device from networks if you suspect active compromise, and seek help from trusted technical support.

• If you shared banking details, approved a payment, or lost money, contact your bank/payment provider immediately. In India, call 1930 and use the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal to report suspected financial cyber fraud.

• Preserve evidence: screenshots, message text, sender details, email, URL, transaction reference, and timestamps.

6. What this assistant can and cannot conclude

The assistant can point out warning signs and recommend safe verification steps. It cannot guarantee that a message, sender, phone number, link, or website is safe based only on its wording. A message with no obvious spelling mistakes may still be fraudulent. Treat an assessment as guidance, not a definitive security verdict.

7. Official reference sources

• **CERT-In Awareness Booklets:** https://www.cert-in.org.in/AwarenessBooklets.jsp

• **CERT-In Digital Safety Compass Handbook:** https://www.csk.gov.in/documents/CERT-In_Digital_Safety_Compass_Handbook.pdf

• **National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal:** https://cybercrime.gov.in/

• **Cyber Crime Portal FAQ:** https://cybercrime.gov.in/Webform/FAQ.aspx

Maintenance note: Educational summary prepared for a prototype knowledge base. Verify official URLs and reporting procedures periodically. Last reviewed: 10 October 2026.